
NEWS

EU budget chief: Less refugee money for Turkey

The European Union's budget commissioner, Günther Oettinger, says the EU should wind down its humanitarian payments to Turkey for looking after Syrian refugees. He said Turkey planned to resettle them in Syria anyway.



Turkey should get less European money for looking after Syrian refugees, the [European Union's budget commissioner, Günther Oettinger](#), said on Sunday.

Oettinger, a member of Angela Merkel's Christian Democratic Union (CDU), told *Welt am Sonntag* newspaper that he thought "in the next tranche, the EU shouldn't make such high payments to Turkey as until now."

He argued that Turkey wouldn't be needing as much money because it was planning to resettle Syrian refugees in the "protective zone" it is currently trying to create in the Kurdish-occupied region of northern Syria.

He also said that many schools, hospitals and shelters had been built with the money already provided by the EU, so the financial need would no longer be as great.

"Furthermore, in future we have to offer greater support to other countries like Jordan or Lebanon," he told the newspaper. "It makes more sense to give the people a permanent home and to finance human dignity than to give them no other choice but to come to us. Every place to live in Turkey or Jordan is less dangerous than the journey to Berlin, and cheaper."

The budget commissioner said that the EU had paid €6 billion (\$6.6 billion) to aid organizations for refugees in Turkey since 2016.

Oettinger also welcomed German Defense Minister [Annegret Kramp-Karrenbauer's plan to set up an internationally protected security zone in northern Syria](#) as a sign that the European Union was seizing the foreign policy initiative.

"After years of Europe's de facto absence from the world's crisis regions, AKK's proposal is a step towards more responsibility from Europeans on security questions," he said.

Some prominent members of the conservative CDU had earlier criticized

Kramp-Karrenbauer for failing to discuss the proposal with coalition partners the Social Democrats first.

bk/ng (Reuters, dpa)

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Turkey: deportation into the unknown

DW RECOMMENDS

Turkey clamps down on Syrian refugees

President Erdogan has threatened to ditch the EU refugee deal. After election losses and faced with escalating conflict in Idlib, the attitude toward the growing number of Syrian refugees has become increasingly harsh. (14.09.2019)

Amnesty: Turkey forced Syrian refugees back into war zone

The human rights watchdog spoke with dozens of refugees who were illegally removed from Turkey and sent back to Syria without a so-called "safe zone" in place. Turkey claims they went back willingly. (25.10.2019)

Don't 'weaponize' refugees, EU's Tusk tells Turkey

The European Council president has told Turkey not to use refugees to "blackmail" the EU with regards to Syria. Meanwhile, NATO's Jens Stoltenberg was more cautious when meeting the Turkish foreign minister. (11.10.2019)

German defense minister floats 'security zone' along Syria-Turkey border

An internationally controlled zone inside northern Syria on its border with Turkey has been floated by Annegret Kramp-Karrenbauer. It follows Turkey's bid to drive out Kurdish fighters and resettle refugees. (21.10.2019)

No-deal Brexit means higher EU bills for Germany, says Oettinger

The EU's budget chief says Germany will have to supply a cash injection of several hundred million euros to the bloc in the event of a no-deal Brexit. A messy departure will leave billions missing from the EU budget. (05.04.2019)